

▼ Figure 44.17

MAKE CONNECTIONS

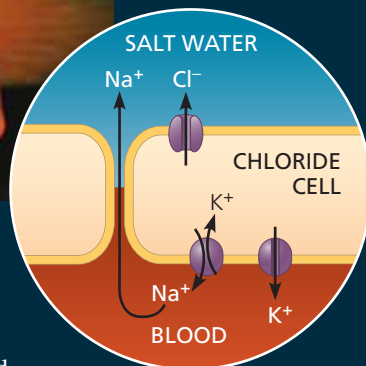
Ion Movement and Gradients

The transport of ions across the plasma membrane of a cell is a fundamental activity of all animals, and indeed of all living things. By generating ion gradients, ion transport provides the potential energy that powers processes ranging from an organism's regulation of salts and gases in internal fluids to its perception of and locomotion through its environment.



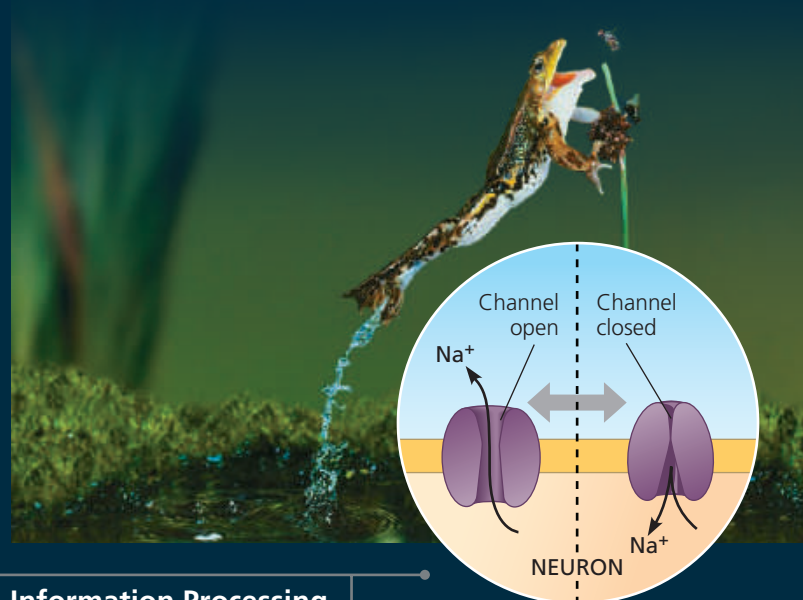
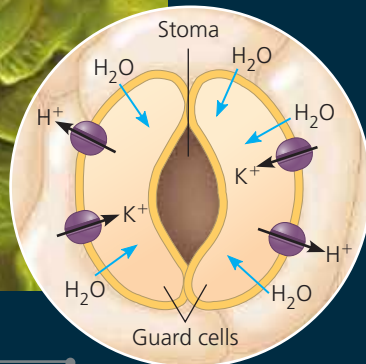
Osmoregulation

In marine bony fishes, ion gradients drive secretion of salt (NaCl), a process essential to avoid dehydration. Within gills, the pumps, cotransporters, and channels of specialized chloride cells function together to drive salt from the blood across the gill epithelium and into the surrounding salt water. (See Figure 44.3.)



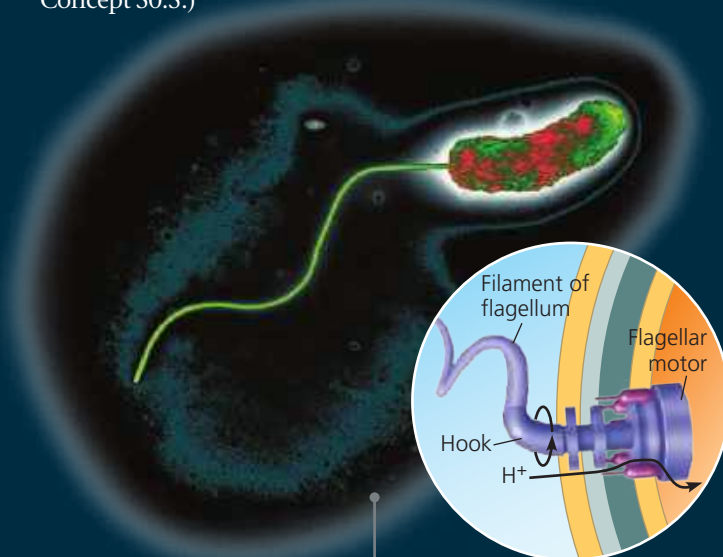
Gas Exchange

Ion gradients provide the basis for the opening of a plant stoma by surrounding guard cells. Active transport of H^+ out of a guard cell generates a voltage (membrane potential) that drives inward movement of K^+ . This uptake of K^+ by guard cells triggers an osmotic influx of water that changes cell shape, bowing the guard cells outward and thereby opening the stoma. (See Concept 36.4.)



Information Processing

In neurons, transmission of information as nerve impulses is made possible by the opening and closing of channels selective for sodium or other ions. These signals enable nervous systems to receive and process input and to direct appropriate output, such as this leap of a frog capturing prey. (See Concept 48.3 and Concept 50.5.)



Locomotion

A gradient of H^+ powers the bacterial flagellum. An electron transport chain generates this gradient, establishing a higher concentration of H^+ outside the bacterial cell. Protons reentering the cell provide a force that causes the flagellar motor to rotate. The rotating motor turns the curved hook, causing the attached filament to propel the cell. (See Concept 9.4 and Figure 27.7.)

MAKE CONNECTIONS

Explain why the set of forces driving ion movement across the plasma membrane of a cell is described as an electrochemical (electrical and chemical) gradient (see Concept 7.4).

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